

Chapter

Where You Are Born, There Is Your Food — The Secret of Local Eating



Introduction: A Very Important Point

Today food from all over the world reaches our plates — Chinese, Mexican, Thai. For the sake of taste, this variety seems attractive. But Acharya Upendra Ji gives a clear principle on this subject, one he himself calls "a very important point":

"This is a very important point: Consume locally grown food."

That is, the grain that has grown in your own land should be your main food.

1. For a Day or Two of Taste, Not for a Way of Life

Acharya Ji explains the meaning of this principle in plain words:

"It means a Chinese man should eat China's food, not you. You can taste Chinese food for a while; it cannot be your way of life."

Tasting foreign dishes is not forbidden, but making them your daily food is another matter:

"So Mexican food, Thai food — only when there is an emergency, or, come on, there is some party, you can eat it for a day or two."

"If you ate it as your lifestyle, then God will say to you: you will get disease."

An occasional taste is fine; but making food that was never meant for you into your way of life is an invitation to disease.

2. Soil, the Earth Element and Prarabdha

Why is this so? Acharya Ji connects the reason to a person's birthplace and karma:

"For a Chinese person, eating in China — that food will be suitable for him. It will be his **karma-rahasya**, the secret of his karma; that is why he was born there."

Being born in a particular land is not chance; behind it lies the secret of one's karma. And one's connection with that land is not merely geographical but elemental:

"That soil is for him, that earth element is for him. What grows from that earth is for him."

The **earth element** (**prithvi tattva**) is one of the five great elements (earth, water, fire, air, space) — the gross, solid element of which both our body and our food are made.

Acharya Ji goes on to say that the quality of what is eaten passes into the one who eats it:

"He is a being who eats the trees and plants grown there; the quality of what he has eaten will be in that very being. That food will be for them — from his **prarabdha**."

Prarabdha is the fruit of past karma that is destined to be received in this life. **The land where you were born through your prarabdha is the land whose food suits your body and your nature.**

3. The Food of Your Own Region

Applying this principle to India, Acharya Ji brings it down to the level of the region:

"You were born in India, you live in India, so Indian food — of your own region. If you are in Bengal, then the food of the Bengal region will be more suitable for you."

"If you are in Maharashtra, then Maharashtra's food — what grows here will be dearer to you. Not only will it be dear; God will have made it suitable for you."

There is a subtle point here: local food is not only **dear to the taste**, it has been **made suitable for you by God**. That is why Acharya Ji urges:

"So develop a taste for your local food — I have said this before."

4. Exploring Is Not Forbidden

This does not mean that every other dish must be given up. Acharya Ji makes it clear:

"I did not say do not explore others. All the other grains, all the other recipes — try them for a change of taste, that is fine. Pick them up, all right."

Then he himself raises a natural question:

"So you will say, 'Oh, I live in Maharashtra, but I really like idli-sambar. Is that okay?' It's okay, no problem, I am not forbidding it."

"Then take it as — so what if I am only from Maharashtra? There is one land called Bharat, isn't there, a big one. I am an Indian."

See your land with a wider view: for a person from Maharashtra, the idli-sambar of South India is also food of the same land of Bharat. Even so, the food of your own region stays at the centre — it is the most suitable for you.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 Consume locally grown food** — let the grain grown in your own land be your main food.
- 2 Foreign dishes are for taste, not for a way of life.** A day or two at a party or in an emergency is fine; making them your daily food brings disease.

- 3 Your birthplace is tied to the secret of your karma and your prarabdha. The soil of that land, its earth element and the food grown in it are made for that person.
- 4 The quality of what we eat comes into us.
- 5 God has made the food of your own region suitable for you — so develop a taste for your local food.
- 6 Trying other dishes is not forbidden — and the food of the wider land of Bharat, like idli-sambar in Maharashtra, is also fine.